Impassioned pleas issued forth from Bharati. ‘Without the wind of public support,’ he said, ‘the Swadeshi ships are floundering. If only two lakh rupees could be raised, the company established by expending so much effort would be put on an even keel.’ Underplaying the daunting challenges, ‘We understand that there are some trifling difficulties,’ he continued, ‘the company’s management will no doubt sort them out in a trice. But is it right that we attempt to solve the troubles only as and when they crop up?’ Raising a comfortable sum was the key. How did the poet propose to raise Rs 2 lakh in two months? He first began by ruling out people who would *not* contribute. The Nattukkottai Chettiars? No, their purse strings would loosen only to empty flattery, dodgy vakils and lazy pilgrim rest houses. The zamindars? No, their riches were meant for whores, liquor and hosting dinner parties for white durais. Sahukars, mirasdars, high-ranking public officials and lords belonged to the same feather. These would only suck the country’s riches dry but would not spend half a paisa for the common good. What then was the solution? We—poor people like us—who earn a daily wage, vakils’ clerks and ordinary workers should join hands and save this noble effort. The desperation in Bharati’s fervent, even frantic, appeals is unmistakable. Of the 160 lakh people in the Tamil country, take away 159.5 lakh; if the rest gave Rs 4 each, the target could be easily met, he suggested hopefully. VOC laid his trust in common people when he founded the company. He is one among us, and never once did he turn to zamindars and sahukars, Bharati reminded his readers.[115]

Bharati also called upon *matathipathi*s (heads of religious monasteries) to support indigenous industry and enterprise. If each monastery would contribute Rs 10,000 or 20,000, industry and handicrafts would thrive. Supporting indigenous industry was the highest form of religious charity, he contended. SSNCo was therefore a fit case for support.[116]

How was one to contribute? Referring to himself in the third person, Bharati said, he was a poor man but from his meagre resources he had remitted Rs 5 to K.R. Venkatarama Aiyar—he did not even ask for a receipt. Of what avail was a piece of paper, he asked. Was it not enough that the